🌳 BEYOND BARS COACHING

Holiday Dopamine Menu + FAST Method Holiday Edition

A Women's Mental Health Toolkit for the Holiday Season 🎄💜

#RebelAgainstRecidivism

How to use this packet: fill it in during our meeting or on your own, then take a photo and keep it on your phone, your fridge or inside your journal. Build it on a day you feel okay, so it's ready on the days you don't. Nothing here needs to be perfect, and every page is yours to change. 🌿

Peer support and education, not medical advice or treatment.

🍽️ Part 1: My Holiday Dopamine Menu

A dopamine menu is a list of things that give you a lift, sorted by how much time and energy they take. When your brain says "I don't know what I need," you pick from the menu instead of grabbing whatever is closest. The holidays add extra pressure, and women often carry most of the planning, hosting and caretaking, so your menu should include things that are only for you.

Menu section	Ideas to borrow	My menu (fill it in)
🥂 **Starters** 2 to 10 minutes. A quick lift between tasks.	Step outside for fresh air. Play one favorite song. Stretch. Sip a warm tea. Send a heart emoji to a friend. Take three slow breaths. Smell something you love.	
🍲 **Entrées** 20 to 60 minutes. A real recharge.	A walk or a yoga flow. A long bath. Baking or crafting. A phone call with someone who gets you. Journaling. A movie night in comfy clothes. A meeting or group.	
🥗 **Sides** Add one to a task you have to do anyway.	A podcast while wrapping gifts. Music while cooking. A walking phone call. A candle while you pay bills. A tea ritual before a family gathering.	
🍰 **Desserts** Fun, and easy to overdo. Set a limit first.	Holiday sweets. New pajamas. A holiday lights drive. Scrolling. Online shopping. Pick a time or dollar limit before you start.	My limit: _____
🌟 **Specials** Seasonal. A few times this season, for meaning.	A cookie swap. A holiday market. A tree lighting. Volunteering. A sober friendsgiving. Writing a letter to someone you love or miss.	

Match the menu to the mood

When I feel...	Try this first	My pick from my menu
😰 Wired, anxious or on edge	A calming starter: breath, tea, a short walk	
😶 Flat, low or numb	An entrée with movement, music or people	
😵 Overwhelmed by the to-do list	A side that makes one task easier, then a rest	
🥺 Lonely or missing someone	A connection item: a call, a meeting, a letter	
😤 Resentful or stretched thin	A solo entrée, and one boundary from Part 2	

🚫 **Not on my menu.** These feel like a lift now and cost me tomorrow (for example: extra alcohol, doomscrolling, overspending, overworking, skipping sleep):

My early sign I'm reaching for a quick fix instead of what I need:

🌳 Part 2: The FAST Method, Holiday Edition

FAST stands for **Foundation, Accountability, Support and Tools**. The holidays stretch every one of them: sleep slips, routines disappear, family dynamics heat up and the calendar fills. Work through each letter and write your answers in the boxes.

🏠 F: Foundation. Protect the basics before the calendar fills.

Ideas to get you started:

- Pick three non-negotiables, such as a sleep window, one real meal a day and ten minutes of movement or morning light.
- Audit your holiday calendar. Mark every event as a must, a want or a no.
- Set a budget for money, time and energy, and decide how many events fit in a week.
- Name the mental load you carry (gifts, cards, hosting, meal planning) and choose what to hand off, simplify or drop.
- Schedule rest days the way you schedule parties.

My 3 non-negotiables:
1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

My sleep window: bed by _____ wake by _____

Events I'm saying YES to: _____
Events that are a MAYBE: _____
Events I'm saying NO to: _____

One thing I'm handing off or dropping this season: _____

My "good enough" holiday looks like: _____

✅ A: Accountability. Make your plan visible, without shame.

Ideas to get you started:

- Choose one accountability person and tell them your three non-negotiables.
- Do a 60-second daily check-in: did I keep my three? What do I need tomorrow?
- Write if-then plans for your hardest moments, so you aren't deciding in the heat of it.
- Do a weekly review on Sunday. Count your wins first, then adjust the plan.
- Track progress, not perfection. A missed day is information, not failure.

My accountability person: _____
How and when we check in: _____

My if-then plans:
If _____ then I will _____
If _____ then I will _____

If _____ then I will _____

My weekly holiday check-in

Week of: _____	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Non-negotiable 1	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Non-negotiable 2	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Non-negotiable 3	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Menu pick 🍽️							
Mood (1 to 5)							

One win this week: _____
One thing I'll adjust: _____

🤝 S: Support. The right amount, from the right people.

Ideas to get you started:

- Support comes in layers. You don't need everyone for everything, and you don't need to do it alone.
- Ask for something specific. "Can you text me at 3 pm on Thursday?" gets a better answer than "I'm struggling."
- Decide who is not on your support list during the holidays, such as people who judge, give unasked advice or drain you.
- Line up an event-day person you can text from the bathroom or the car.
- Give support too, but don't make it your only role.

Ask script: "Can you check in with me by text on _____ at _____? I don't need advice, just a quick hello."

Support layer	Who	How and when
📱 **Daily touch** 1 or 2 people for a quick text		
🗓️ **Weekly anchor** A meeting, group, coach or therapist		
🎉 **Event-day person** Someone to text during a gathering		
🆘 **Hard-day person** Someone I can call, even late		
💛 **Crisis** Call or text 988 any time, day or night	988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline	Call or text 988

🧰 T: Tools worksheet. Decide your tool before you need it.

Tool ideas to borrow:

- **Body:** 5-4-3-2-1 grounding, a double inhale with a long exhale, a walk, a warm shower, stretching.
- **Mind:** write for five minutes, name the feeling in one word, use a "good enough" rule, talk to yourself like a friend.
- **Words:** a boundary script ready in your notes app.
- **Plans:** your own ride, a time limit, a drink in your hand, a walk outside, a planned exit.
- **Comfort kit:** tea, a playlist, a scent you love, a small journal, a fidget, a photo of why you started.

When this happens...	My tool is...	Where it lives
🚪 Before a gathering		
😵 I feel overwhelmed		
⚡ An urge hits (a drink, food, spending, a text I shouldn't send)		
🔥 Family tension or an old pattern		
🌙 I can't sleep		
📉 I feel guilty or like I'm not doing enough		
🕯️ I'm missing someone or feeling lonely		
🛁 After a hard event		

Boundary scripts to borrow (and make your own)

- "Thank you for inviting me. I can come for two hours."
- "I'm not going to talk about that today. How is your week going?"
- "No, but thank you for thinking of me."
- "I've got it covered this year, so I'm skipping that tradition."

My own boundary sentence: _____

My exit plan for a gathering (my own ride, my time limit, my signal, my person to text):

What's in my comfort kit: _____

📝 Part 3: Reflection Questions

Use these if we have time, or take them home and write in your journal. You don't have to answer them all, and you don't have to share any of them. 💜

1. Which holiday expectations are mine, and which did I inherit from my family, my culture or social media?

2. Where do I carry the mental load of the holidays (planning, gifts, hosting, emotional caretaking), and what could I hand off or let go of?

3. What does "good enough" look like for me this season?

4. When have I said yes while my body was saying no? What did I feel afterward?

5. Which relationships fill me up this season, which drain me, and what boundary would help?

6. How do I talk to myself when I fall short of the picture-perfect holiday? What would I say to a friend in my place?

7. Who or what am I missing right now, and how can I honor them in a way that feels gentle?

8. What would rest without guilt look like for me this season?

9. What are my early signs that my mental health needs extra care, and who will I tell when I notice them?

10. What do I want to be able to say about myself on January 2?

💛 **If things feel heavier than a journal can hold:** reach out to someone you trust or a professional. In the U.S., call or text **988** any time, day or night. You can also text HOME to 741741 to reach the Crisis Text Line, or call the SAMHSA National Helpline at 1-800-662-4357 for free treatment referrals.